

SUPPLEMENT: PREPOSITIONS BY & UNTIL

"By" and "until" are both prepositions of time, but they indicate different things. "By" indicates a deadline or a specific point in time by which something must be completed. "Until" indicates a period of time up to a specific point in time. Essentially, "by" signifies completion before a certain time, while "until" signifies continuation up to a certain time.

BY & UNTIL describe a time limit.

"BY" means "no later than" or "at the point in time when."

- EXAMPLES: I need an answer **by** next Tuesday. (= no later than)
We should have your car repaired **by** 4 o'clock this afternoon. (= no later than)
By the time you read this letter, I'll already be on my way to California. (= at the point in time when)

"UNTIL" expresses how long an activity has continued or will continue.

- EXAMPLES: They'll keep talking **until** you tell them to be quiet.
Seth lived at home with his parents **until** he was 25.

Use "UNTIL" with "HAVE" or "GIVE" to express a deadline:

- EXAMPLES: You have **until** midnight on April 14 to file your taxes.
I'm giving you **until** tomorrow morning to turn in your homework.

Use "BY" with "NEED" or "HAVE TO" to express a deadline:

- EXAMPLES: You need to file your taxes **by** midnight on April 14.
You have to turn in your homework **by** tomorrow morning.

NOTE: "Till" or "Til" are INFORMAL forms of "until."

→ ...and are NOT generally ACCEPTABLE in Academic Writing

PRACTICE:

Fill in the blank spaces in the following sentences (1 - 20) with either **BY** or **UNTIL**.

- (1) Please let us know _____ next Wednesday if you're planning on coming to the wedding.
- (2) You have _____ 3 o'clock to finish the exam.
- (3) The store closes at 6 p.m., so if you want to get your shopping done you'd better get there _____ 5:45.
- (4) You need more time to finish your essay? Okay, I'll give you _____ tomorrow, 5 p.m.
- (5) We stayed at the beach _____ sunset.
- (6) I will be home _____ 5:00 PM. Then I'm going out.
- (7) I will be home _____ 5:00. Come over any time after that.
- (8) The application must be in _____ the 31st to be accepted.
- (9) The photographs will be on exhibition _____ the end of the month.
- (10) The film didn't end _____ eleven o'clock.
- (11) The movie will be finished _____ 9 pm.
- (12) There's a room free in Bob's house next week but you can stay with us _____ then.
- (13) His work was so stressful that _____ the end of the day he was worn out.
- (14) I was up _____ three o'clock trying to get it finished!
- (15) We'll leave on Tuesday -- always assuming the car's repaired _____ then.
- (16) _____ the time we finished dinner last night, it was too late to go to the movies.
- (17) We didn't arrive at our hotel _____ after midnight.
- (18) I need an answer _____ next Tuesday.
- (19) Shouldn't we wait _____ Antony's here?
- (20) Can you repair my car _____ Friday?